

GROUP OF DEATH

THE WORLD FOOTBALL TOURNAMENT

for 1 to 8 players

How to play

Welcome!

Once every four years, the whole planet stops to watch. Borders blur, work pauses, and strangers embrace in the streets as nations pour their hopes into 11 players and 90 minutes — this World Tournament is more than football; it's where a country holds its breath together, where unknowns become immortal and giants are humbled by teams no one believed in.

Group of Death puts that drama in your hands. You'll manage a nation through the group stage and into the knockout rounds, living every twist of fortune: the wonder goal, the heartbreak of a shoot-out, the fairy-tale run of an underdog with nothing to lose. It's a game of nerve and belief, where the dice tell the story and no lead is ever safe — so gather your courage, read the game, and chase the only thing that matters. Glory.

This little book teaches you by playing. You'll be rolling dice within a couple of pages. Don't worry about the numbers and tables — they all live at the back (or at the References deck), ready for whenever you need to look one up. For now, just follow along.

The whole game in one line

Find the Edge, roll the die. Learn that idea and you already understand how football matches are decided here. Everything else is just the fun on top.

The only idea you need: the Edge

When two teams meet, one is usually better than the other. The difference between them is what we call the Edge — and the Edge decides everything.

Let's say you're managing **Brazil** — one of the best teams in the world. Your first opponent is **Japan**, a good side, but not quite at Brazil's level.

Brazil are **strength 4**. Japan are **strength 2**. So your Edge is $4 - 2 = 2$ in your favour. You're the favourite by two.

Here's the only thing to feel: **the bigger your Edge, the more likely you are to score, and the less likely they are.** A level game is a coin-flip. A big Edge means you'll usually win — but football being football, never always.

Let's play a quarter

A match is played over four quarters. Each quarter is quick: a card, then a roll. Let's play Brazil's first quarter against Japan.

1. Draw a card

You draw one **Match Event** card — a little twist of the game. You get "*Counter-Attack (+1)*". Brazil break fast! For this quarter your Edge jumps from 2 to 3.

2. Roll the die

You roll **one die**. With an Edge of 3 in your favour, most numbers are good for you — only a 6 lets you down. You roll a **3**. That's a goal! **Brazil 1, Japan 0**.

“How do I know if a roll scores?”

Simple rule of thumb: the bigger your Edge, the more of the six numbers score for you. At a level game you score on a 1–2; with a big Edge you score on almost anything.

You don't need to memorise it — the exact ladder is on your reference card and at the back of this book. One lovely detail: **a 6 is always a “no goal”**, so even the best team can be kept out. No result is ever certain.

3. Do it three more times

Play four quarters just like that — draw a card, roll the die — and add up the goals. That's a match. You just managed one!

Winning a match

Most goals across the four quarters wins. In the group stage, a draw is perfectly fine. In the knockout rounds there are no draws:

- **Still level after four quarters?** Play one more quarter — extra time.
- **Still level after that?** It's penalties — a pure, nerve-shredding coin-flip shootout (more on that at the back).

Setting up the tournament

Now that you've felt a match, here's how a whole tournament is built. There are 32 teams, split into 8 groups of four. Every group has one team from each level — a giant, a strong side, a dark horse, and a minnow.

1. **Drop the Group of Death token** face-down on any group except Group A (more on this soon — it's the group nobody wants).
2. **Deal the teams** so each group gets one of each level. The very first top team dealt goes to Group A and becomes the *Defending Champions*.
3. **Hand out Storylines** — shuffle the deck (it's mostly blanks) and deal one face-down to every team, then flip them all over.
4. **Pick your team** — choose one, or draw at random for a real challenge.
5. **Kick off!** Before each match, both sides roll a die — higher is home, and home kicks off.

The things that make it sing

Those are the bones. Here are the four things that turn a dice game into a story — each one is small, and you already met a couple of them.

Storylines — the season's headlines

Before kick-off, some teams are dealt a Storyline: a stroke of luck or trouble that changes their strength all tournament. A wonder striker might add +2; a locker-room bust-up might cost -2. Most teams get nothing at all — which is exactly why the ones that do become the stories everyone talks about.

Match Events — the twists of a game

The card you draw each quarter. A red card, a wonder goal, a saved penalty, the crowd roaring you on — each one nudges the Edge for that quarter, then it's gone. This is the chaos of live football, and it keeps every quarter alive.

Momentum — your moment of magic

Win a match and you earn a Momentum card: a special move you play later, exactly when you choose — a last-ditch clearance, a penalty you simply cannot miss, a tactical masterstroke. You can only ever hold one, so timing is everything. They only ever help you.

Tactics — how you set up

Each half, you decide how your team plays — place your meeple on Attack, Control, or Defend:

- **Attack** — go for it: re-roll the die for another shot at a goal.
- **Control** — keep your options open: draw two event cards and keep the one you like.
- **Defend** — dig in: +1 to your Edge, the classic way an underdog frustrates a giant.

Playing against a friend, you both choose in secret and reveal at the same time — a proper mind-game. Pick the same tactic and you cancel out; pick differently and you each get your perk.

The Group of Death

Every tournament has one — the brutal group where there are no easy games. In this game it's real, and it gives the box its name.

Remember that token you placed blindly at setup? That group is the Group of Death. Inside it, the underdogs come alive and the giants can't coast — everyone's dangerous. And because it was placed face-down before the teams were dealt, it might just land on you. Survive it and you've earned your place.

The rest of the world

Here's the clever bit that keeps a whole World Cup moving fast: you only ever play your own matches. Every other game in the tournament is settled in seconds with a single quick roll — and you only bother resolving the teams you're actually about to face. No rolling out sixty games you'll never watch.

Playing with friends

From 1 to 8 can play. On your own, you chase the trophy against the game — a background opponent handles itself with a quick roll, and it never gets to peek at your plans.

With friends, you each manage a nation. Most of the time you're playing your own matches — but when two of you are drawn together, it's head-to-head: you both draw cards and choose tactics in secret, then reveal. These are the tensest, most gleeful matches in the whole game.

A quick example: a match against a friend

Head-to-head plays like any match, with one twist: each half you both draw a card and choose a tactic in secret, then reveal together. Here's one quarter.

You're managing **Argentina** (strength 4); your friend has **Brazil** (strength 4). A dead-level derby — Edge 0.

Kickoff. You both place a tactic face-down. You pick **Attack**; your friend, expecting it, picks **Defend**. You reveal together — different choices, so you each get your perk: you'll get a re-roll, and Brazil take +1 Edge to soak up the pressure.

The cards. You draw *"Free Kick (+1)"*; Brazil draw *"Injury (-1)"*. Each card goes on its own team — your +1 cancels Brazil's Defend bonus, and their -1 tips the quarter your way: net **+1 to Argentina**.

One shared roll. A head-to-head quarter uses a single die, read from the favoured side — you. You roll a **5** — a near-miss. But you played Attack, so you use your re-roll and get a **2**. Goal! **Argentina 1, Brazil 0**.

That secret choose-and-reveal is the heart of it: every quarter you're trying to out-think the manager across the table.

That's everything!

You now know how to play. Keep the reference cards handy for the exact numbers, lift the trophy, and enjoy the ride. The tables on the next pages are only there for when you want to check something mid-game.

Reference — all the numbers

You won't need these to learn the game — they're here for when you're mid-match and want to check a value. Anything the game asks you to look up lives on these two pages (and on your reference cards).

Team strength

Level	World rank	Strength
Tier 1	1–8	4
Tier 2	9–20	3
Tier 3	21–36	2
Tier 4	37–64	1

The Edge = your strength – their strength. Storylines shift strength by +2 / +1 / –1 / –2. Dice-free tie-break: strength → tier → rank.

The quarter — who scores

Edge shown in your favour. If the opponent is favoured, swap the “You” and “They” columns.

Edge	You score	No goal	They score
0	1–2	3–4	5–6
+1	1–3	4–5	6
+2	1–4	5	6
+3 or more	1–5	6	—

A 6 is always “no goal” — no result is ever guaranteed.

Tactics

- **Attack:** re-roll the quarter die (keep the 2nd result).
- **Control:** draw 2 event cards, keep 1.
- **Defend:** +1 Edge in your favour.

Set at kickoff, halftime and extra time. Head-to-head: choose secretly, reveal together — same cancels, different = each gets their perk.

Solo — choose yours first, then roll the rival's tactic. If the rival rolls Control, draw one event card for it and apply that to the rival this quarter:

Die	Rival is underdog	Rival is favourite
1	Defend	Defend
2–3	Defend	Control
4	Control	Control
5	Control	Attack
6	Attack	Attack

Momentum

- **VAR Check** overturns a goal / Red Card / penalty — but never a Goal of the Century or Hand of God.

Resolving background matches

Groups — roll one die per group (the Form Die):

Roll	Effect
1–3	Form holds
4–5	Tier 3 +2
6	Tier 4 +3

Then rank by strength; top two advance (ties → higher tier). Group of Death (background): 1–2 Tier 3 +1 and Tier 4 +1 · 3–4 Tier 3 +2 · 5–6 Tier 4 +3.

Knockouts — the underdog advances on (the Cup Die):

Edge	Underdog goes through on	Chance
0	coin-flip (diff tiers → higher tier)	50%
1	5–6	33%
2	6	17%
3+	— (favourite wins)	0%

Standings & penalties

- **Penalties (pure 50/50):** each kick 1–3 = goal, 4–6 = miss. Home kicks first; 3 kicks each, then sudden death.